

The best solar charger we have come across is undoubtedly the Brando Universal Solar Charger. Apart from mobile phones, this device supports all kinds of portable media players, laptops, digital cameras, etc. Tech enthusiasts will appreciate this wide compatibility with one glance at our clutter of charger cables.

The gizmo has been around for some time and has received rave reviews across the Internet. It's a pity it has not taken off.

Setting up the Brando Universal Solar Charger is easy. As with most such devices, the first charge will have to be through an AC outlet, to get the built-in battery primed. Then, simply open the flap of the device and point it towards the sun. Ensure that the colour switch is set to On, and you are good to go.

Once you want to start charging one of your devices, just hit the 'Off' button and hook it up to the universal plug. The universal plug supports seven different kinds of connectors, which include most of the popular mobile phones and even formats such as miniUSB. Funnily, the plug connects to the charger via regular USB, there is no USB out on the other end.

When in charging mode, Brando even lets you adjust the output voltage going to your phone; although as long as it is below 4.5V, this should not be a concern in most cases.

While the solar charging part is great, it is a bit slower than normal charging. Still, you will be using this rarely and mostly when travelling. When you are sitting at home, just plug the universal charger into an AC slot and use the other end to fit the mobile device of your choice.

We cannot vouch for the service nor want to be held responsible if something goes wrong; but in the past, we have had a good experience purchasing products from Brando over their Web site (usb.brandocom.hk).

Product: Brando Universal Solar Charger

Price: \$69 + \$3 for shipping (Rs 3,500 approx)

Note: Users might want to be on the watch for a new product from US-based Kinesis Industries (www.kinesisindustries.com): The K3 is a charger for mobile phones, digital cameras and other tools that derives its power from solar as well as wind energy!